Nikos Christodoulides on Why India Must Lead What Comes Next | Nikhil Kamath | People by WTF

Can I ask you how does it feel to be in power? How does it feel to be the president of a country? This conversation was different. Nikos isn't a politician who knows history. He's a historian who became the president of the Republic of Cyprus.

A nation that's the bridge between Europe and the Middle East, which is a wild place to be running a country right now. Just that made him so different from everyone I've spoken to and made me redefine my idea of what a politician can be. And honestly, I think I left with more questions than answers.

Hopefully, things like AI will lead us to a point where studying history and philosophy become a lot more relevant all over again. I'm a bit concerned with this technological progress. I'm a bit concerned how it's going to be in 10, 20 years.

What's going to happen if AI replaces 80% of the workforce? I hope this is not a scenario, but we're talking about the future scenario. That they will lose their work. How they will react? Can I ask you something? Sure.

Why you ask for this interview? Would you like coffee? Yes, please. La Coffee? Espresso. Espresso.

How would you like me to address you, Mr. President? Nikos. Nikos? Yes. So you start your days early, is it? You'll ask me, we start already? So I wake up every day at 5.30 in the morning.

I'm going to the gym at 6. I spend an hour and a half there. 40 minutes running and then doing some exercise. And it's the best way to start my day.

A long day. I'm trying always every day to have a power nap for 45 minutes around 2.30, 2 o'clock, 2.30. And then I start again up to 10, 11 o'clock. That's my everyday program.

Power nap is a... It's a Mediterranean habit, but it's very important. It is a must. I love the fact that you're a historian first and an academic.

So when I was going through all that you have accomplished in life, which is so much, the thing that really stood out for me is historian. I feel like so much of what is happening today has happened in the past, but we don't pay enough attention. You're right because, you know, history repeats itself.

And it's very important to understand what happened in order to, you know, in a way predict what is going to happen. And especially when we are coming from a small country, in a region of great geopolitical importance, the most important element of Cyprus, if you ask me, is geography. We connect Europe with the Middle East, with the Gulf, with Africa.

So it is very, very important to understand the past. So studying history in a way, it is an advantage. And especially, you know, studying in the United States, when I decided back in, when I graduated from high school, 1991, I had to go to the army for 26 months.

It is a mandatory to go in the army in Cyprus. Now it's 14 months, not 26 months. So when I finished my military services, I decided to go to the United States for two reasons.

The first one, it was my brother was there. So it would be much more easier for me. And the second one, it was the majority of Cypriots, they used to go and study in the UK.

Because of this special relationship that you also have. Both of us used to be... Do we call it special relationship? Love and hate relationship, I call it even today. And the second reason, it was much more in the financial point of view, it was much more easier to go and study in the United States because it was possible to work.

University fees were much cheaper. This is not the case today, but anyway. So I went to the United States and I think it influenced in a very decisive way how I approach everything.

There is an American dream. At least it used to be an American dream. I don't know how the situation is today.

So studying in the United States, when I was growing up, I always wanted to get involved with politics. But when I went to the United States to start my studies, I ended up wanting to follow an academic career. It was fascinating for me.

Studying there, learning about international politics. It gave me a lot to understand the world, especially from the perspective of the United States, great power. And it influenced decisively the way, even today as a president, I approach, you know, the issues that I have in front of me.

You have such a rich Greek history in that region of philosophy and theology and a bunch of, I think at one point in our history, in the world's history, it was at the forefront of philosophy. What resonates to you? Which school of thought from all the years studying history that you think most mimics what's happening in the world today or something can be derived from there to learn about today? As I told you, I mean, history repeats itself. So we see different eras of historical developments.

We see a lot of commonalities. But I think that for me, the fascinating about history is the post-World War II history. You wrote about this, right? You wrote a book about it.

Yeah, and how the international system was developed after World War II, how small states were influenced by the developments. I mean, in a way, following the collapse of the Cold War, you remember Francis Fukuyama and some other, they told about the end of history, that we're entering a new era, that all countries are going to work together, cooperate for the common

cause, et cetera. But when I was studying in the United States, there were actually two school of thoughts, the realist school of thoughts and the idealist school of thoughts.

And I was always believing in this realist school of thoughts, that states, they always compete who is going to be the leader. So even after the collapse of the Cold War, you know, I was expecting that in 20, 30, 15 years, we're going to go back to this, you know, anarchic, in a way, international system. And we're seeing this today.

And I'm witnessing this at a time, not from the academic point of view, which is much more easier, but being a leader of a country that is located in, as I told you before, in a region of great geopolitical importance, a country that is under Turkish occupation, a country that tries to, you know, balance between different interests, with them always to support and promote the interests of your country. And it's here that I really believe that India can play a leading role, biggest democracy in the world, seventh biggest country, geographically wise, fourth biggest economic power today. And we really see a lot of commonalities with India, starting from the past, our past, our struggle, anti-colonial struggle.

And today approaching, I mean, I can really say that we see eye to eye on almost all international issues. So I'm visiting the country at a time when we hold also the presidency of the Council of the European Union, one small member state of the European Union. You know, every six months we have the rotating presidency and Cyprus now holds proudly the presidency of the Council of the European Union.

Prime Minister Modi visited Cyprus last June. It was the first visit after 22 years. And following our discussions there, we turned a new page in our relations on what we can do together at multilateral level.

And I really believe that the sky's the limit when it comes to how we can work together. And following the recent developments in the region, in the Gulf, with Iran, et cetera, I really believe that we need a new architecture in the region, security architecture, trade architecture, the way that we work together. So like-minded countries like Cyprus, India, I can name more countries, we need to work together, to work together on a positive agenda, not to come together against a third country.

To come together, to work on a positive agenda, always for the benefit of our region. And of course, at the end of the day, of our people. So I'm looking forward to our discussions tomorrow.

You're seeing him in Delhi? Yeah, I'm going tomorrow in New Delhi. It's a state visit. I will see the prime minister.

I will see, of course, the president. I will see the foreign minister. He's a very good friend of mine.

I used to be a foreign minister. He's excellent. I will say that I remember our discussions.

He always has this, it's academic, but also, you know, sometimes they accuse the academics that, you know, it's much more easier to, as an academician, to predict, et cetera. But when you are a politician, real time, and you need to take decisions at difficult times, it's much more difficult. But it's very important to have the academic background to know what happened.

This is very, very important. What do you make of PM Modi? He's an international leader. I really believe that you are blessed that you have Modi as a prime minister of India.

He's internationally respected. And I think now is the time for India to enhance its role, to play an international role. And that is why we are also supporting, we talk, we start our discussion from history.

Following the World War II, we have the new international system with the UN. I'm just giving you an example. With five permanent members with a veto power.

Russia, US, UK, France, and China. Those five, they were the great powers following World War II. Today we have a different international system.

So if we want to give credibility to the UN, and I really believe that we need to give more credibility to the UN. We need an international organization under which, you know, the international system functions. We need to expand the UN security, the permanent members of the UN Security Council.

And India should be the first one that be included. So I see this new geopolitical role of India. I'm very glad that as a European Union, I'm putting now the heart of the presidents of the Council of the European Union.

We reach an agreement on the free trade agreement between the European Union and India. We're talking of a market of two million people. I'm very glad that Prime Minister Modi was on a tour in Europe, in Italy, Norway, Finland.

Yeah, I've been watching his tour right now and he seems to be relentless in the energy he has at the age that he is, which is so impressive. And I asked him, what is the, you know, the secret behind this energy? He told me yoga. Every morning.

Have you tried yoga? No, unfortunately. You should try while you're here. Maybe when you go to Delhi tomorrow.

You said earlier, Nikos, that all states compete and have to compete. In such a world, do the institutions of post-World War II, be it the UN or the World Bank, any of the institutions that have thrived at that point of time, do they have the relevance they once had today? Or have they become more committed to helping their patron states, the winners of these states competing with each other, the countries that have won in capitalism? We need international institutions. We

need the UN.

We need the World Bank. We need the international agreements that all of us are buying with. But the system that we have today reflects the realities of 1945.

I mean, following World War II. The realities today are completely different. That is why, for example, India should be included as a permanent member of the Security Council.

We need the international institutions. We need the international norms. All the time, we need to update those international institutions and international norms to reflect today's reality.

I agree with you 100% that India needs to be a part of it. But will that change the outcomes these institutions are trying to drive? Yes. Because it will give to these institutions much more credibility reflecting today's realities.

We need to have an open and frank discussions on giving relevance to the international institutions that were established following World War II, the international trade system, and make them relevant to today's reality. Because what is the reason behind the United States changing their policies? Tariffs, unitary foreign policy against multilateralism, etc. Because you see that today's international system is not relevant with today's realities.

That is why we need to change it. We need to update it. Because at the end of the day, all of us will follow an approach of just serving our interests in the long run.

I mean, in the short run, we may see some interests, some gains. But in the long run, it's going to be a lose-lose situation. Even beyond World War II, these institutions, in a way, like if you were to consider how the international economy was modelled from Bretton Woods to the dollar being on the gold standard to going out of it, in a way, the institutions have been modelled in a manner to favour the incumbent and the incumbent since World War II to now, to a large part, I would say the transition from the British incumbency to American happened pre-World War II, in my opinion.

But have these institutions not favoured the incumbent? In a way, yes. Especially at the beginning, they were the ones that established those institutions. So they established them in a way to serve their interests.

What is the difference today? We are living in a very interconnected world. Let's go in the Gulf and what's going on in the Gulf with Iran, Israel, and the countries of the Gulf is something that influences also the United States, which geographically is very far away. It influences everybody.

What's happening in India influences also the situation in the United States. So the world today is much more interconnected compared with the way it was in 1945. So the institutions that were established following World War II, and we needed those institutions, we need to update these institutions to reflect today's reality and how interconnected our world is.

Don't the Americans seem to be projecting that because they are not dependent on international energy per se, in America they claim is energy sufficient, and they care less about... Not in the long run though. Not in the long run. Even with this crisis in the Gulf, we see the prices of diesel, oil in the United States going up.

So there is no country that is not affected by the situation in the Gulf today. How do you think it plays out? Like as somebody who has a lot more access and insight into the subject than I do, when I watch it as a businessman, as an entrepreneur, it all feels very stupid to me. I feel like nobody in most modern wars beyond a point of time, nobody remembers why they started fighting in the first place and what the outcome they tried to achieve when they began versus what they want now or they claim they want now is completely different.

If you were to wager a guess, what happens next? What happens in Iran? What happens in America? What happens between the new blocks that seem to be getting created? You know, it's not easy to predict, but I can tell you what I want to happen. We are trying. It's a very small country.

I mean, our share on what we want the situation to be. And that is why I mentioned before, we need a new architecture in our region. Security architecture, trade architecture, economic architecture.

Based again, I'm mentioning this on a positive agenda. We're not going to dictate to India, to Iran, how they will behave internally, externally, etc. What is our responsibility? It's the like-minded countries of the region.

When we see the same future, or the future that we want to see, to work together in order to safeguard for our countries, our people, and our region, the future that we want. It's very important to work on a positive agenda. You know, always we're going to have differences between states.

What we need is the framework to solve these problems and these challenges. And for sure, war is not the solution to solve. Because with the war, the easiest thing is to start the war.

The most difficult is to finish it. So that's why I'm insisting on the international institutions, the importance of the international institutions. Because international institutions, they put the framework under which any disagreements, differences, different approaches should be addressed.

And that is why, for me, India has a leading role to play as the biggest democracy. Because India believes and supports multilateralism. We don't see unilateral actions from India.

We see India supporting the international system. But the international system that was established following World War II should be developed in order to be relevant with today's

realities. Do you believe in democracy today? We don't have an alternative.

If the outcome is economic well-being of a country and growth, do you think democracy is the best bridge to get there? It's the only way to get economic progress and the well-being of the people. Isn't... I'm not, like, championing the cause of an anti-democracy thing at all. No, no, let's just figure it out.

Because we see a tendency, especially in Europe, we see a lot of threats to democracy today. Let's go to social media. I don't know what is the situation in India.

But everybody, everybody, through social media, they can promote, you know, they read something that doesn't reflect the reality. And immediately, it's becoming viral. And you see a lot of people questioning institutions, democracy, elections.

So, we see a lot of threats to our democracy today. Yeah, no, I love democracy. But when I read history, like, say, we had city-states before we had nation-states.

They were never very democratic in nature, the ones that thrived. Democracy, kind of, like, I feel like I can argue both sides of the case. The recent example, like, when Trump was in China last week, and he was speaking to Xi Jinping, he brought up Greek philosophy, and he spoke about the thesis of this.

And, the trap of... He's so relevant today. Yeah. He was always relevant.

And he's Greek, right? Yeah. He's from your region. He spoke about wars don't happen because of bad leaders or misunderstandings.

They happen because of structure, and pride, and ego. And when somebody is a challenger, and you start to see the challenger seriously, there is bound to be a war. I can extrapolate this down to families, and brothers, and companies.

I think it's innate human tendency, which he kind of captured very well. And it was, I think, very opportune for Xi to have brought it up. But... This is true.

How we face this. This is true. It's a human nature, it's the nature of states, of countries, etc.

How we face this threat. The only way to face this threat is to have international institutions, the framework, the international framework to address threats, perceptions, you name it. We need the international framework to discuss those issues.

And the international framework is the UN, is the, you mentioned before, the World Bank, etc. And those international institutions, they need to reflect today's reality. Because if they don't reflect today's reality, then they don't have any validity.

But do international institutions only work with the patronage of the largest economies of the

world, which they don't seem to have at this point of time? Certainly the largest economies. They need to reflect their international realities today. And how relevant is the UN Security Council permanent members if you don't include countries of like India, and I will not stay in India, Brazil, or the countries of of those countries that today they play a special role.

That's why we need to update the international system to reflect today's realities. Right. And if you had to update it in your lens, say create a new international institution, can you paint that picture for me? How would you create an institution? I will start from the regional level.

I will start from first to connect the region with Europe. It's much more easier to start, you know, building the puzzle. So, India, connecting India with the Gulf, with the Middle East, with Europe.

It's a win-win situation. And when you say connecting, what do you mean? For trade? Not only trade. To institutionalize our relationship, you know, I mean, trade, economy, approaching international issues, everything.

Through a regional organization, something like the Organization for the Security and Cooperation in Europe that we had in 1975. What happened in 1975? Because the international system, the UN system, following 1945, in a way excluded a lot of countries. In 1975, we have the Organization for the Security and Cooperation in Europe, a regional organization, not an international one, like the UN.

Because the countries of Europe, they see the benefit out of this cooperation. So, let's start with a regional organization, starting from India, to Europe. Give substance to this, trade, economy.

And at the end of the day, all of us participating in this regional organization will see the benefits out of this cooperation. And we expand this with more and more regions. Do you suspect this might be causing the conflict we see today, that the ceasefire is a trap of China challenging the incumbency of America? I think in today's very challenging international system, you see the way the European cities, I will talk with the European cities.

I mean, the most important country in Europe used to be the United States. Because the intervention of the United States in World War II saved Europe, brings democracy, pro-democracy in Europe. And the transatlantic relationship was the most important bond for the Europeans.

And we see today the Europeans, because of tariffs, because of Greenland, because you name it, questioning the transatlantic relations. That's why I brought up democracy in the previous conversation. If the winner of today's time or the challenger to the incumbent of today's time has been built not on the back of democracy, very like, not in theory, but very pragmatically.

I think they have a version of, I don't want to put a term to it, but not democracy, which is also competitive and kind of policymaking can be longer in tenure and they don't have to worry about

the next election. That affords them the ability to make a plan for 10, 20, 50, 100 years. Whereas countries which are democratic have to kind of figure out every four or five years how to appease a majority of the country, which might not necessarily be what is right for the long-term outlook of that country.

Does democracy work from that lens? We're in a transitional period. And that is where we have a responsibility. Transition between? Transitional period from the system that was established following World War II and then the collapse of the Cold War to the new system that is going to be in the next 20, 30, 50 years.

Okay. And that is why democratic countries, like-minded countries, we need to come together. And in the long run, this will influence all those, also those countries that today they don't share the same values, the same principles as we do.

So we have a responsibility. First of all, towards our people, but then our region, the international system to come together and work together. And that's why for me, it was a game-changer, this new approach of the European Union with India.

It is a free trade agreement, but it's much more than an economic and trade agreement. It is a strategic agreement that will change the international system. And I'm very glad that I'm dealing with Europe, I will say, since 2013.

I was a government spokesman, then the Minister of Foreign Affairs, now the President. It's the first time that I see my European colleagues understand the importance of the greater Middle East. And when I say greater Middle East, I include Eastern Mediterranean, Middle East, Gulf, India.

In the past, they used to approach our region. I will mention this publicly. I mean, I don't have any problem.

I'm not a diplomat anymore. Through a no-colonial approach. Always criticizing the region.

We violate human rights. There is no rule of law, etc. But at the same time, when they wanted to sell something to the countries of the region, military equipment, you name it, there was, you know, no violation of human rights, and the rule of law was okay, etc.

So it was through mainly a no-colonial approach that they were coming in our region. And I see this changing now. And we're changing because today we are living in an interconnected world.

What's going on today in the Gulf doesn't influence just India, Cyprus, Greece, UAE, etc. It influences all the countries. Even the United States, which geographically is very far away from this region.

Mm-hmm. So we see this new approach to our region. And if you go back, what is the reasons?

Again, their interest, because interest is the one that influences the way we approach situations.

And we see this political willingness to work together. So we need to take advantage of this crisis because crisis always gives a lot of opportunities. And out of this crisis, we build a new architecture in the region.

And when I say region, I start from India and go to Europe and work together. And this will also send a message, a positive message, because we are going to work together on a positive agenda. We are coming together, not against a third country.

For those countries that can join this this cooperation. And we need we need the country to play a leading role. And I think India can play this role.

30, 40 years before the Indian prime minister to be so warmly welcomed in all these European countries. A hundred years ago, I wouldn't imagine it. You see? I see the way that they are welcoming today, Prime Minister Modi in Europe.

Why the free trade agreement wasn't possible? The free trade agreement was announced on January. It was the first week of our presidency of the Council of the European Union. Why this free trade agreement wasn't even discussed before five and 10 years? Because international developments today, they make all of us the Europeans, India, we understand the need to come closer together.

Someone wise in history had said, I wouldn't know, but probably you will, that if there are warriors, there will be war. What worries me, Nikos, is in a world where everybody is upping their defense budgets, either out of choice or out of somebody else's volition, the increased defense budgets does not necessarily mean a safer world. I think it means a more violent world.

But if you want to avoid war, you need to increase your defense budget. It's the only way to avoid war. But if everybody were to increase their defense budget and sit with a whole bunch of more weapons than they already have, I don't know if that avoids war or creates war.

I see. I fully see your point, but we didn't reach that stage that we believe war is an avoidable. So we need to increase our... Why we did it in Europe? In Europe, I remember always discussing about the need to enhance our defense and security.

We had a lot of discussions. But we never took the decision because we were at the end of the day, we were saying we have these excellent transatlantic relations. In case of a need, we have the United States that will come and support us.

Today, or the last three, four years, especially following what happened in Ukraine, the Russian invasion in Ukraine, we understood as Europeans that we cannot be dependent on the Americans. And so we start investing in our defense and security, in having our strategic autonomy on defense and security, on trade, on economy. At the same time, we are more also

useful to the United States.

We are not doing this in order to go to a war with the United States. On the contrary, we cannot rely in Europe on the United States. And we saw what happened in Ukraine.

It's a European territory. As Europeans, we have a responsibility to defend the European territory and not expecting from a third country, the United States, which is far away. They are not influenced by the situation in Ukraine to defend our interests.

If I have to learn from somebody who is a historian, an exceptionally intelligent man who has written some great books. This is a far extrapolation, Nikos, but these are questions I kind of ask myself when I'm reading some books or whatever. Do countries, the very concept of countries, the concept of borders, the concept of armies, make sense for a more evolved world? Aren't all people the same at the end of the day? At the end of the day, we need to be all the same.

How you avoid the war? Nobody wants war, right? So how you avoid the war? If we create a situation that the risk for a third country to start a war is so high that it will make the country to think two and three times before starting a war, is the only way to avoid it. And that is why I'm insisting on institutionalize the regional cooperation, starting from India to Europe. And Cyprus really is the entry point, the gateway of India to Europe.

Create an organization, I repeat myself, on a positive agenda in order not to give the impression to the country that all those countries are coming together against my interest. Out of this cooperation, all of us, we are going to see benefits. Sending indirectly the same time the message to those countries that are not part of this organization that I have a benefit to join this organization.

In order to join this organization, I need to behave in a certain way. Not, or put it a different way, respecting the sovereignty, the territorial integrity and independence of India. Because if I'm going to question and challenge the territorial integrity and the sovereignty of India, I will be excluded by this regional organization that is giving so many benefits to the countries that are participating and to their people.

Politics of tomorrow, do you think the world will move left or right? In which way do you lean personally? You mean left and right, ideology-wise? Also economy-wise. I really believe in ideology because, you know, today some people, they say there are no ideologies, et cetera. I fully disagree with this.

I see more to the right, center to the right. I think the left can also what's happening in the Soviet Union, they failed. It may be very good in textbooks, in academia, but the reality is much more different.

So I see the world going to center to the right. Left didn't work out historically, so there's no

precedent for it, really. But one can assume- When we say left, I mean, we mean Marx, we mean Lenin, we mean Stalin, we mean what's left.

If you keep going left, you probably ended some version of communism at the extreme. So many of the names you mentioned. But communists in China, communists in the former Soviet Union, communists in Eastern Europe.

I feel like communism in China was like, at least during Mao, when he had the Cultural Revolution, he was reciting Marx to a great extent, right? He at least said, this is some place to take inspiration. So I would say communism of that kind, if you keep walking left. Let's move our discussion from the theoretical and go to the practical.

I mean, on the issue of ideology. How I see, at least, I really believe in the free economy. But at the same time, as a president of my country, I believe that I have a responsibility to provide to my citizens respecting of their economic situation, social status, where they stay in the country, the same rights and benefits when it comes to two sectors, education and health.

Those sectors, I have a responsibility to provide the same opportunities, either you're poor, you're rich, you live in the city, you are in the village, etc. So, health, education, access to social services. As a government, I need to provide to my citizens all the rights.

But on the issue of the economy, if you work much more than I do, you should have more. It's simple. This transition from an academic to a politician, has it been tough? Interesting.

I would say interesting because I did a lot of research on archives, preparing the books that I published. You read the minutes out of a meeting. And you just read what they said, what they discussed, etc.

It's much more different to be present in the meeting. And if someone raises his or her voice, body language, that was my first shock when I moved from academia to politics. You need though, academia in politics.

Those that they don't know what happened, they are in much more challenging position to deal with current crisis, let's say. Maybe, hopefully, things like AI will lead us to a point where studying history and philosophy become a lot more relevant all over again. I'm a bit concerned with this technological progress.

I see a lot of benefits. AI in medicine. But I'm a bit concerned how it's going to be in 10, 20 years.

What's going to happen if AI replaces 80% of the workforce? We go left. You go left or you question democracy? Both. You question maybe governance as well and wonder if... And we end up in an anarchic system, more anarchic than the government.

Or a very structured world not run by humans, but systems. So I have some doubts about that. I

see the benefits out of the technological progress.

There are a lot of benefits for all of us. But I'm a bit concerned with how it will develop in the future. There's so much productivity around AI which is being localized in between a couple of companies.

I don't see another scenario if this trend were to continue. These companies will have to be nationalized in one way or another. And then maybe some form of UBI, like Universal Basic Income.

I mean, in order to be protected. In order for the people of the country not to... the ones who lose the jobs, the 80%, not to walk into these companies with bricks and try and break it down. I hope this is not the scenario, but we're talking about the future scenario.

But they will lose their work. How they will react? Was this right? Like in... You're more in left, huh? I'm not in left. I'm a capitalist.

You're in right, you're in center. I'm exactly where you are, center of right. Because of history.

I feel this is the problem with the world that there have been experiments on the left most of which have not worked out. They say that the best is not the best. You need to be close to the left when you are 18, 19, when you study.

And then after 30, when you see the reality, you are centered to right. In academia, you may have more left than right. But in politics, you have more right than left.

Another thing they say is you can be left in your house with your family. You can be a little bit left in your society, in your mini society. But as the group keeps getting bigger, trust generally breaks down.

And we don't have a successful example of left in order for today, I mean, to apply it today. What is the successful example of left? I mean, China keeps coming to mind, but China is also not truly left. I think China has a system where the mayors compete and different cities are competing with each other.

I think when the transition happened from Mao to Deng Xiaoping, he kind of, he turned right without saying he turned right. He did one thing very smartly where I remember some of his speeches. He would say, he would begin with praising Chairman Mao and then say things which didn't agree with his philosophy, saying right looking things.

But because he started and finished with Mao being great, people forgot the center. It's a good way for a politician to change slowly. And politicians, they need to change.

I mean, you don't need to be dogmatic. You need to be able and change. And be brave and go

out and say, you know, I was believing this.

I was saying this. However, the reality is different. And I need to follow a different path.

And the world needs a new kind of politician. You're kind of part of that, like somebody with the academic lens going there, like younger politicians, different kind of politicians. It's very important when you are in a position of power.

To decide, to think and decide without thinking the next elections, but thinking the next generations. And being a historian, it helps me to understand this because you may do something today. Please, everybody having the newspapers, next day newspapers, the best articles, the best coverage.

But in the books of history in 50 years, it will say he or she failed. That's why when you are in a position of, you know, you need to decide every day. You need to think that the next generations and not the next elections.

And if you win in the short term, Napoleon said a very interesting thing. History is generally written by the winners of tomorrow. So even if you won one or two election cycles, history wouldn't care too much about it.

So thinking about the next generation will also, today we have a crisis on the institutions. It's much more easy for people to question the government, the president, the prime minister, the parliament. They're doing this every day.

But you need those people to be part of the democratic elections. You mentioned before democracy. We discussed democracy because it would be a failure for all of us if we end up in a situation that the majority of the people decide not to go to participate in democratic elections.

And then you have the minority. You have people less than 50% of the population deciding about who's going to be the prime minister, who's going to be the president, the parliamentarians, et cetera. We keep coming back to history so much because I'm inspired by your background in history.

Someone said, the best people for positions of power are people who don't desire power too much. The problem with politics of today is the people in positions of power are the ones who most desire power. Today? Today.

This is Cyprus cheese. Yeah, halloumi. Halloumi.

Yeah, I heard. I like halloumi. It's a European Union-produced product and we export here in India.

Actually, it's the number one export product of Cyprus. Going back to your question, I mean,

nothing wrong for someone if you want to go to a position of power to become a prime minister, a president, et cetera. What is the most important is going to a position of power to have a clear vision where you want to get your country.

If you don't have a clear vision, you end up dealing with everyday issues. And you don't help your country, you don't help your people. And if you're just dealing with everyday issues, your main concern is the next elections and not the next generations.

It's sitting behind the office of the president. You need to understand that you cannot change everything. Okay? You need to be very specific.

And always keep in mind that changes will come probably after you leave the office. Can I ask you, how does it feel to be in power? How does it feel to be the president of a country? It's a very lonely role. You need to, every day, to take difficult decisions.

And that is why you should never forget that you are here in order to change your country, not to please the voters the next day and having good articles in the press and care more about good books in the future. Very well said. I mean, let's go to President Trump.

You see some reactions through X. I'm going to put 30% tariffs tomorrow to European products or Indian products. And you see a lot internally in the US, you see a lot of positive reaction on this. When the time passes, you see that even President Trump understands that we need to discuss, we need to find a way, because what is important is what is going to happen, not the reaction the next day.

And also, it's very important to know that what you are doing, there is an end day. It will not be forever. It's also very important.

Keep in mind. For Cyprus and India, I wanted to ask you this. Most people watching this would not have thought of Cyprus that much in their life, like Indians, the Indians that are watching it, like, which is a half of my audience.

They'd have thought of Cyprus for a minute in their lives, maybe, because it is a small country. It's a million and a half people. What is the opportunity, not for a government, not for policy, policy, but for individuals and businesses in India to engage with Cyprus? What is the low-hanging fruit? An Indian business person that invests in Cyprus, immediately, he or she has an access to the market of 450 million people, the European market.

At the same time, he has access in a very promising region, which is the greater Middle East, the Gulf and the Middle East, in a predictable, reliable country with security. We are following the common law, as you have here. So, it's giving a lot of advantages to an Indian business person that decides to invest in Cyprus.

But we approach India, not just as a market, it's much more. India for Cyprus is much more than

a market. I told you before that, we should try on all international issues.

So, we are in a country, a friendly country, like-minded country. You are in the region at the same time you are in Europe. You know, the biggest advantage of Cyprus, if you ask me, is our geographical position, because we connect Europe with the region.

And if you ask me, one of my vision when I became president is to really connect Europe with the region, and Cyprus being the bridge between the two. And we have the DNA to do it. If I were to look at you like a CEO of a company with a million and a half people, how do you build a country to succeed, like you would be a CEO of a startup, for example? First of all, you need to succeed internally.

If you don't have the ingredients, the DNA, what I told you before, you cannot succeed externally. So, the most important for a CEO, I'm not a CEO, I was never a CEO. The first thing that was my priority when I was elected is to enhance all the power parameters of my country, starting internally.

Strong economy, for example. And I'm proud that in this time of crisis, international crisis, the first, I mean, we had the publications from the European Union last week, the first three months of 2026, Cyprus having the highest growth rate in Europe, 3%. We have conditions of full employment.

The public debt is almost 50% of the GDP. So, internally, we have the DNA in order to go outside, within always the limits of Cyprus and being a small country, to play the role I told you. But the most important is internally, we have the DNA.

And I'm very glad that we have a lot of investments, foreign investments in the country. They approach Cyprus, as I told you before, as an entry point to Europe, but also as an entry point in the region. And we can play this role.

We're talking about a democratic, predictable, reliable country in a region of great geopolitical importance. Both you and your wife are diplomats. Yeah, yeah.

She's still a diplomat. Any learnings from that, a career in diplomacy? Of course. Of course.

I need to learn how to be more diplomatic. That's what I mentioned before. I'm not a diplomat anymore and I will be more frank.

It was a learning experience. I mean, being a diplomat of a small country under occupation, serving in... If you ask me what is the first thing that has come in my mind from my diplomatic career, if you go and approach a foreign diplomat or a foreign country and ask to support you in your national issue, what is our number one, what is our national issue? The fact that Turkey still occupies 37% of the territory of the Republic of Cyprus. So I need support in order to face this

challenge.

So if I'm going to approach a German diplomat with the aim to get the support of Germany and I go there and I just talk about the Cyprus problem, the Cyprus problem, the Cyprus problem, having the impression that we're at the center of the world and that every morning they wake up in Berlin and in Moscow and Washington thinking about Cyprus, I failed. It's very important. First of all, to know his challenges, discuss about his challenges, align your interest with his country interest and at the end, the last issue that you're going to raise is your issue.

So it teaches you how to negotiate very well. Yeah, also negotiations. You never open all your cards from the beginning.

I've tried to learn this. Especially because it's different if you're the diplomat of Cyprus and if you're a diplomat of the United States. If you're a diplomat of the United States, you go there, you ask what you want.

So it depends from the country that you represent. So if I were a diplomat of India, for example, the ability to think what the other person is thinking much less of what I want, but what does he want and negotiate like that is a very valuable skill set. It is because what is important is when you finish a meeting as a diplomat, what your colleague will think after you leave and not what he or she mentions during your discussion.

But thank you, Nikos. This was great. Any fleeting message for India? Indians can approach Cyprus as the bridge, what I told you before, bridge, the gateway to Europe.

Cyprus for India is in this very challenging, anarchic world. To finish with the way we start, a country that is predictable, a country that is reliable, a democratic country, which is in democracy, a country that it sees eye to eye with India on all international issues. We have common challenges, but at the same time, we have a lot of opportunities that we need to take advantage always for the benefit of our people.

Your team told me you have five more minutes. They extended. Is there anything you'd like to talk about? Did you know Cyprus before? I've never been.

I'd love to come. So you need to come. I'll come.

I'll come. But can I ask you something? Sure. Why you ask for this interview? When I read historian, it piqued my interest.

That's actually the honest answer. I'm a big fan of history and philosophy. I wish more people in the world were.

So when I said historian, I was like, great, get to learn something today morning. And if I may say, there's something very genuine and curious about how you approach life, which is quite

appealing. So let's end up with history.

We need international institutions and international norms. But we need to update them and be relevant to today's reality. We need a regional organization, starting from India, going to Europe, based on a positive agenda without excluding everybody, anybody.

But at the same time, those that they want to join this regional organization, which is based, I repeat it, on a positive agenda and not against their country. They need to follow certain rules. And I really believe that this will be attractive also for those countries that they don't join at the beginning, because you will see the benefits for the countries that they are participating and their peoples to join us.

And through this, I really believe that in the long run, we will avoid also wars or difficult situations like the ones we're witnessing today in our region. And I'm saying this based on historical, not experience, based on history and what happened in the world. And in this, in order to happen, India has a special leading role to play.

Anything outside? Like, how about life in India? What are you looking forward to in the next day of being here? Unfortunately, my associates, they gave me five minutes. They didn't, you know, they didn't give me free time even for an hour to see India. I was here back in 2017, Mumbai and New Delhi.

You know, we're a small country, almost a million, actually. We have a very vibrant Indian community in Cyprus. Really? Yeah, 15,000.

I mean, for Cyprus, 15,000. I mean, don't compare with the Malayali Indians everywhere. Yeah.

So, I know a lot about Indian culture. I remember, it was 1982 or 1983. I was 10 years old in elementary school.

Indira Gandhi visited Cyprus. How come? You know, both Cyprus and India were part of the non-alliance movement, common history, this love and hate with the British, the British, excellent relations, always. And I remember that day, and I remember that all the kids from school, they went to the streets, you know, to welcome here.

It was very important for Cyprus. It was probably the most important visit following the establishment of the Republic of Cyprus. The establishment of the Republic of Cyprus was in 1960.

So, of course, in Cyprus, everybody knows India in a very positive, you know, when they hear India, they have a very positive perception. How is the landscape of Cyprus? Like, I really want to come. Is it very Greeky? Like, is it like going to Athens or Mykonos or something like that? It's close, but we have our unique characteristics.

I'm sure that if you visit Cyprus, you will enjoy it, you will like it. And we can repeat this interview in Cyprus, next to the beach. I'm sure that we have a lot of developments, regional and international, very soon.

So, and to continue our discussion. The next time you come to India, if you're able to evade your team for a while, I'd love to take you out for a drink. I'll show you the real India without the protocols.

Unfortunately, I don't have the chance to see real India. Yeah, but come back. It's a fun place.

I feel like when you're not seeing the sterile version, which has been like weaved. If you don't go and work in the streets, talk to the people, you never understand. I'll take you to Goa and Bangalore, which will be fun.

Thank you, Nikos. Thank you so much for doing this. Thank you very much.

I had fun. Thank you. Cheers.